



THE DREAMER:
Kumar stands tall

70

WAS THE NUMBER OF OFFICERS IN AN ANNUAL BATCH OF IAS IN THE 1950s.

TODAY, EACH BATCH CONSISTS OF 400 OFFICERS

inability to speak in English. "But with the help of friends and tutors, I am overcoming this problem," he says. Kumar's is an unlikely face among the elite cadre of officers. Course coordinator at the academy Akashdeep Chakravorty says, "This batch shows the highest variety and new trends. There are 13 disabled trainees, more and more selected candidates now take regional languages as a medium of examination and nearly one fourth of those selected are women."

Kumar is the embodiment of the changing face of the administrative services. Male or female, from small town or big, for Indians like Kumar, all it takes is determination and the will to follow their desire to take the road less travelled to the mission to be accomplished.

MOTOR RACING

Chennai | TAMIL NADU



Formula won

He's barely 18 and not eligible for a driver's licence but that doesn't stop him from leading a talented team of motor racers

■ By Akhila Krishnamurthy

Akkineni Anand Prasad has a dual personality—racy roadster when in his car and a shy teenager when out of it. As a toddler, Prasad was fascinated with cars, and had a huge collection of it. Err, toy cars? "No, real ones," he says with a straight face, "I would sit on my grandfather's lap and he would drive me around." No surprise

then that before he memorised his alphabet, he knew how to drive a car.

Obviously, at 17-and-a-half, Prasad, a Class XII student, is still wet behind the ears. But for the last 10 years, he's been living in the fast lane. And enjoying it. He may not be eligible for a driver's licence

yet, but is the proud owner of a motor racing licence from the Motor Sport Association of India. He also holds the distinction of becoming the youngest team leader in the world, under his home-grown banner, Gemini Racing. He made his debut at the Lanson Toyota Go-karting championship in Chennai, 1997, at the age of seven. Last year, with only two days of intense training from racer and trainer, Akbar Ebrahim, Prasad drove his first Formula car at the J.K. Tyre National Championship, and finished third. "The real thrill is how to take the corner in a perfect line," he says.

For him, motor sports is a science and an art. That explains why the deafening roar of his car is music to his ears.

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YEARS AGO MOTOR
RACING STARTED
IN INDIA WITH
CIRCUIT
RACING

HOT WHEELS: Prasad on the go

